Luigi Pio Tessitori — Veli Krisana Rukamani Ri (1919)

The Boneyard is a collection of works left unfinished, unpublished, or unread at their authors' deaths — dry bones in the valley, in Ezekiel's image. Each presentation tells the scholar's story, weighs what survives of his work, and states plainly what completing it would take, so that a book the world never received whole can be met at last. Each of them was one of one. There will never be another like him, and his light will not shine again except through the work he left behind.

A Boneyard dossier — researched and presented by Robert Tilford, Hays, Kansas. Filed 17 October 2026.

Disclosure: prepared with AI assistance — the six subject reviewers named in the index are AI agents, each desk-checked at this desk; all rulings and final decisions are the author's own.

Dedication

To Luigi Pio Tessitori of Udine, who crossed to Rajputana at twenty-six and gave five years to its bardic libraries. This presentation is for the young editor who finished his Italian version of Prithviraj's poem at Bikaner, carried his English to verse 244 of 305 — sixty-one verses from the end — and for the poem that waited for that promised English voice.

The author's own terms

Dingala, in Tessitori's usage, is the literary language of the Charana bards of Marwar — the language of the *Veli* itself — treated by him within Old Western Rajasthani, his name for what had been called Old Gujarati. It is not a mere dialect of Hindi, nor to be conflated with Pingala. His edition followed his own two-part scheme, from his 1915 Progress Report: Part I, the Dingala text with readings and critical notes; Part II, the English translation with historical introduction and explanatory notes.

The story

Luigi Pio Tessitori was born in Udine on 13 December 1887. He took his degree in the humanities at Florence in 1910; the folder's dedication records his

doctorate as a study of the *Rāmcarit Mānas*. On Sir George Grierson's recommendation he led the Bardic and Historical Survey of Rajputana, arrived in India in 1914, and spent five years cataloguing private bardic and princely state libraries, despite bureaucratic opposition. At Bikaner, from 1915, he showed that the dialect hitherto called Old Gujarati should more properly be called Old Western Rajasthani.

His eye reached beyond language. He noted proto-historic ruins in the Bikaner–Ganganagar region predating Mauryan culture, enabling the later discovery of Kalibangan, and in 1919 communicated three Kalibangan objects to Grierson — one a seal with characters he could not identify. He died before he could show them to Marshall, at Bikaner on 22 November 1919, aged thirty-one, of Spanish influenza contracted on the return voyage.

The work and what survives

The *Veli Krisana Rukamani Ri* is a poem of Krishna and Rukmini in 305 stanzas, composed about 1581 (Samvat 1637) by Prithviraj, a Rathor prince, drawing on the *Bhagavata Purana* and coinciding with it, in Tessitori's account, only in the main narrative thread. Its last twenty-eight stanzas, 278 to 305, form the conclusion.

What Tessitori printed is Part I: Bibliotheca Indica New Series No. 1423, Baptist Mission Press, Calcutta, 1919 — the Dingala text, collated from manuscripts, with notes and a glossary; his printed notes run to verse 305. Part II never appeared in print. What survives is manuscript, in the Archivio Peano: 157 numbered sheets, inventoried by Fausto Freschi, carrying two translations. The Italian version, finished at Bikaner on 22 August 1917, is complete. The English, begun at the same time, ends at verse 244. Other critical editions of his likewise survive only in manuscript, beside his printed Survey catalogues.

Its English fortunes

The project folder holds a complete fresh English version of all 305 verses, made from the 1919 edition, so that the verses Tessitori Englished and the sixty-one he did not arrive in one voice. Beyond that desk, the finding stands at a bounded strength: **no complete English translation of the *Veli* was found after research** — the folder's verdict, checked October 2026, and nothing in

this pass contradicts it. Two bounds belong with it. The only English *Veli* described anywhere is Tessitori's own manuscript, ending at verse 244; the only complete second-language version described is his Italian manuscript. No exhaustive WorldCat or national-catalogue search for later partial renderings was run, and the Archivio Peano manuscript was not inspected, so no stronger wording is used.

What completing it would take

The folder's fresh version already covers all 305 verses. Completing it would mean verifying it verse by verse against the Calcutta page images, not the noisy OCR layer, using Tessitori's notes, glossary, and introduction summary as the folder's method prescribes, with every flagged uncertain line re-checked by a reader of Dingala and Old Western Rajasthani — flagged, never silently smoothed. It would also mean running the hardened catalogue check before any wording stronger than the bounded finding above is used, and resolving a small divergence over his 1919 home leave between the folder and the external biography before dedication text is set from either. Tessitori's name and his Part I and Part II structure stay at the front: the text, notes, and glossary are his; the English voice is the completion.

Sources

- Project folder: ~/workspace/rare-and-obscure-books/books/tessitori-veli-krisana-rukamani-ri/tessitori-veli-krisana-rukamani-ri.txt (base64-encoded)
- https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Luigi_Pio_Tessitori
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